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OVER THE MOON

Chandrayaan-3's success is set to redefine the trajectory of the Indian space sector

BY MANISH PANT

► **IF SEVERAL WISE** men over millennia have revealed that a failure today may pave the path for future success, India's national space agency—the Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro)—has amply demonstrated it by successfully landing the Chandrayaan-3 spacecraft near the moon's South Pole on August 23. This achievement makes India only the fourth after Russia, the US and China to perform a soft landing on the lunar surface, and the first to do so on the moon's dark side.

Once the news of Vikram Lander

A NATION'S DREAM

(Clockwise from top) Chandrayaan-3's Pragyan Rover ramps down from the Vikram Lander; the Vikram Lander after landing on the moon; PM Narendra Modi and Isro Chairman S. Somanath celebrate after Vikram's landing; on August 27, the Rover came across a crater three metres ahead of its location

touching down on the lunar regolith—bombarded by meteorites, solar particles and cosmic rays since the time earth's natural satellite came into being—broke at 18:02 IST, the nation of 1.43 billion people erupted in euphoric celebrations. The convergence of 8 million viewers on YouTube to witness the triumph of Isro scientists broke all records previously set during the 2022 Football World Cup matches and music video releases by the South Korean boy band BTS. In his congratulatory address from the BRICS summit in South Africa, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, alluding to the country's future interplanetary ambitions, said, "We refer to the earth as our mother and the moon as our *Mama* (maternal uncle) in India. '*Chanda Mama* is quite far away' used to be the refrain. Soon, children will say things like, '*Chanda Mama* is just a tour away.'"

"This is not the work of us alone. This is the work of a generation of Isro leadership and its scientists. This is a journey we started with Chandrayaan-1, continued with Chandrayaan-2... and this (Chandrayaan-3) is a huge incremental progress," Sridhar Panicker Somanath,